

You still haven't said anything about the noise next door

9 findings · 11-step checklist · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Saying nothing isn't neutral. Holding it in keeps raising your own stress and pulling the two of you further apart, and your shorter hellos read to them as **much less** than they feel to you.

THE GOAL

You're finding out whether they even know, and what happens once you say it. Greet them normally the next time you cross paths.

CHECKLIST

You cross paths with them, in the hallway, at the mailboxes, taking the bins out, anywhere you'd normally just nod and keep walking.

- ☐ Greet them the way you would if none of this had happened, not the **shortened version** you've defaulted to.
- ☐ If they're rushed or not alone, don't start now. Name a real time to catch them later, like "can I grab you tonight?"
- ☐ If it's a workable moment, name the specific sound and when it happens in one plain sentence.
- ☐ Say it as something they might not know, not something you think they've been ignoring.
- ☐ In the same breath, ask for **a specific fix**, such as turning the volume down at night.
- ☐ If they look surprised or say they had no idea, take that at face value instead of assuming they're covering.
- ☐ If they push back or downplay it, repeat the one fact once, calmly, rather than adding more examples.
- ☐ If they agree to something, repeat it back in one sentence so you both leave with the same version of it.
- ☐ Write down whatever you agree on somewhere you'll see again, specific enough to check later.
- ☐ End the exchange on an ordinary note, a normal goodbye, not an awkward retreat.
- ☐ Before you separate, decide your own fallback if nothing changes, a follow-up text or the building office, so you're not starting from nothing.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Hiding your irritation doesn't make things **neutral between you and a neighbour**. It still raises stress and lowers closeness for both of you.
- 2** Your shorter hellos feel obvious to you, but people are **surprisingly bad** at reading what's going on inside someone else.
- 3** Waiting this long doesn't make you unusual. In three cities surveyed, **roughly half or more** never said anything to anyone.

What your silence is and isn't telling them

KNOW

Hiding your irritation doesn't make things **neutral between you and a neighbour**. It still raises stress and lowers closeness for both of you.

Hiding a strong reaction still reads as stress and distance to whoever's across from you. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Your shorter hellos feel obvious to you, but people are **surprisingly bad** at reading what's going on inside someone else.

People hiding a strong feeling, like disgust, consistently believe it shows more than it does to whoever's watching. [Source 2](#)

Whether the problem is you

KNOW

You assume you'd be the person making a fuss, since **nobody nearby has said anything** either.

Most people underestimate how many others secretly feel the same way about something like this. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Being bothered by a neighbour's noise isn't a personal quirk. It ranks among the **top sources** of everyday noise annoyance.

The same pattern shows up across cities, suburbs, and rural areas alike, not just crowded buildings. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Waiting this long doesn't make you unusual. In three cities surveyed, **roughly half or more** never said anything to anyone.

Even among people who did act, most went through a building office rather than the neighbour directly, in two of three cities. [Source 5](#)

Why this looms bigger than it should

KNOW

You're picturing this as worse and longer-lasting than it will be. People **reliably overestimate both**.

Students placed in a less-wanted dorm predicted a miserable year, then ended up about as happy as everyone else. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

You're assuming this goes badly if you ask. People **consistently underestimate** how often the answer is just yes.

Across more than 14,000 requests, people underestimated how often the answer would be yes. [Source 7](#)

What to say

SAY

Say it plainly instead of hinting: "I've been a bit off lately, and it's this: the noise through the wall has been getting to me." Your quietness was **never going to say that for you**.

Your quietness alone was never going to explain what it meant, however obvious it felt to you. [Source 2](#)

SAY

Ask directly for the fix you want, instead of only describing how annoyed you are. A direct ask like that gets a plain yes **far more often** than you'd expect.

A direct, plain ask gets a yes more often than people expect it to. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/search?query=EXT_ID:12899316&format=json&resultType=core
2. https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/search?query=EXT_ID:9731312&format=json&resultType=core
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7. <https://ecommons.cornell.edu/server/api/core/bitstreams/445e3b34-ce08-4f5b-8671-466f49963d40/content>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Neighbours at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)